

DEVIL'S ADVOCACY

Challenging a single, strongly held view or consensus by building the best possible case for an alternative explanation.

WHEN TO USE

Devil's Advocacy is most effective when used to challenge an analytic consensus or a key assumption regarding a critically important intelligence question. On those issues that one cannot afford to get wrong, Devil's Advocacy can provide further confidence that the current analytic line will hold up to close scrutiny. An individual analyst can often assume the role of the Devil's Advocate if he or she has some doubts about a widely held view, or a manager might designate a courageous analyst to challenge the prevailing wisdom in order to reaffirm the group's confidence in those judgments. In some cases, the analyst or a team can review a key assumption of a critical judgment in the course of their work, or more likely, a separate analytic product can be generated that arrays all the arguments and data that support a contrary hypothesis. While this can involve some analytic time and effort, when a group of analysts have worked on an issue for a long period of time, it is probably wise to assume that a strong mind-set exists that deserves the closer scrutiny provided by Devil's Advocacy.

VALUE ADDED

Analysts have an obligation to policymakers to understand where their own analytic judgments might be weak and open to future challenge. Hence, the Devil's Advocacy process can highlight weaknesses in a current analytic judgment or alternatively help to reaffirm one's confidence in the prevailing judgments by:

- Explicitly challenging key assumptions to see if they will not hold up under some circumstances.

- Identifying any faulty logic or information that would undermine the key analytic judgments.
- Presenting alternative hypotheses that would explain the current body of information available to analysts.

Its primary value is to serve as a check on a dominant mind-set that can develop over time among even the best analysts who have followed an issue and formed strong consensus that there is only one way of looking at their issue. This mind-set phenomenon makes it more likely that contradictory evidence is dismissed or not given proper weight or consideration. An exercise aimed at highlighting such evidence and proposing another way of thinking about an issue can expose hidden assumptions and compel analysts to review their information with greater skepticism about their findings. The analyst could come away from the exercise more certain that: 1) the current analytic line was sound; 2) the argument is still the strongest, but that there are areas where further analysis is needed; or 3) some serious flaws in logic or supporting evidence suggest that the analytic line needs to be changed or at least caveated more heavily.

THE METHOD

To challenge the prevailing analytic line, the Devil's Advocate must:

- Outline the mainline judgment and key assumptions and characterize the evidence supporting that current analytic view.
- Select one or more assumptions—stated or not—that appear the most susceptible to challenge.
- Review the information used to determine whether any is of questionable validity, whether deception is possibly indicated, or whether major gaps exist.